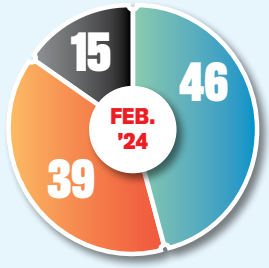
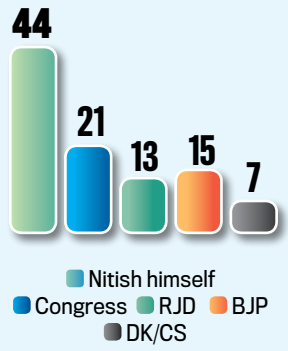
Q. Do you think Nitish Kumar joining the NDA has ensured the defeat of the I.N.D.I.A. formation in the 2024 Lok Sabha election?

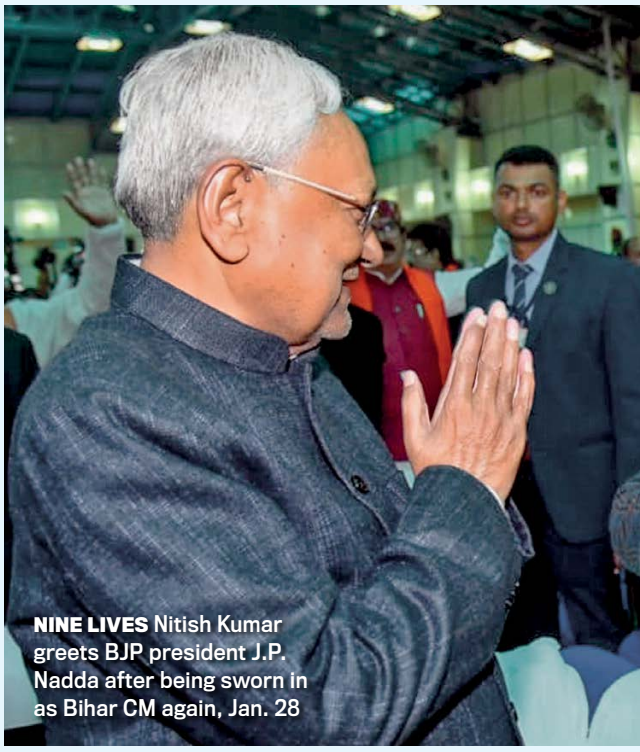


The JD(U) chief's switch could be a body blow to the Opposition alliance

Q. Who is to be blamed for Nitish's exit from I.N.D.I.A.?



The Bihar CM's legendary U-turns are not a surprise anymore

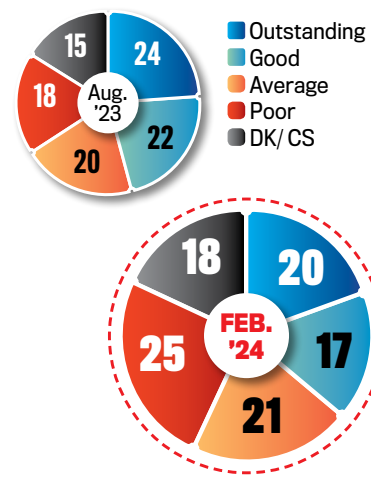


NINE LIVES Nitish Kumar greets BJP president J.P. Nadda after being sworn in as Bihar CM again, Jan. 28

Not surprisingly, a majority of the respondents in the INDIA TODAY Mood of the Nation Poll conducted between December 15, 2023, and January 25, 2024, expressed no enthusiasm for I.N.D.I.A. for the coming general election. Only 31 per cent of the respondents, down from 33 per cent six months ago, believe the alliance can defeat the BJP-led NDA in the election. And 46 per cent of the respondents say that Nitish joining the NDA has already ensured the defeat of I.N.D.I.A. Election strategist-turned-political activist Prashant Kishor has predicted a clean sweep for the NDA in Bihar, and the exit of Nitish and Mamata has diminished the prospect of a united fight against it in 82 Lok Sabha seats. The entire construct of I.N.D.I.A. revolved around one strategy—consolidate the anti-BJP votes by fielding common candidates in as many seats as possible. More than a third of the respondents were amenable to the idea of regional parties coming together to form a government at the Centre—37 per cent feel regional parties represent local interests at the national level. The support seems to have been squandered now.

However, the good news is that Rahul is still seen as the best bet to lead an Opposition alliance against Modi, with 21 per cent of the respondents backing him, a marginal drop from the previous poll. In the past year, the Congress leader has been uncharacteristically consistent in his political discourse and public visibility. He has, on many occasions, led the party's attack on the PM in Parliament. In fact, he has taken care to recast himself as a caring and accessible mass leader, a far cry from the 'Pappu' caricature the right-wing troll army had made him out to be. He has also found new ways to reach out to the masses by releasing on social media his interactions with

Q. How would you rate Mallikarjun Kharge's performance as Congress president?



The honeymoon period is over, and Kharge has offered very few solutions